

Savanna monitor

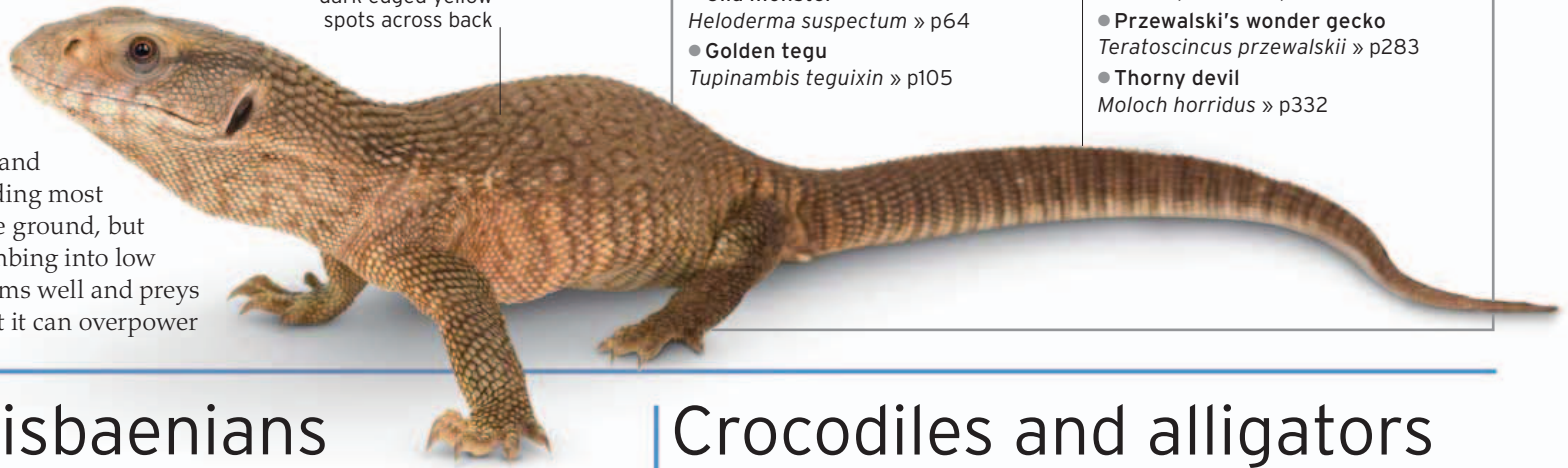
Varanus exanthematicus

- ↔ 3–5 ft (1–1.5 m)
- 📍 Sub-Saharan Africa
- ⊗ Locally common

Monitors include some of the largest of lizards. They have powerful bodies and sharp claws—and most are opportunistic in their feeding habits. This species is widespread across Africa in open woodland and grassland, spending most of its time on the ground, but occasionally climbing into low trees. It also swims well and preys on anything that it can overpower

—including invertebrates and small vertebrates. Its chief predators are martial eagles and rats, and it is sometimes eaten by humans, despite legal protection. Savanna monitors breed in the wet season. Females dig nests and lay about 20–50 eggs.

rows of circular, dark-edged yellow spots across back



Other species

- **Armadillo lizard**
Ouroborus cataphractus » p235
- **Australian water dragon**
Intellagama lesueurii » p342
- **Common flying dragon**
Draco volans » p298
- **Fabian's lizard**
Liolaemus fabiani » p113
- **Friilled lizard**
Chlamydosaurus kingii » pp324–25
- **Gila monster**
Heloderma suspectum » p64
- **Golden tegu**
Tupinambis teguixin » p105
- **Henkel's leaf-tailed gecko**
Uroplatus henkeli » p243
- **Jeweled lizard**
Timon lepidus » p157
- **Marine iguana**
Amblyrhynchus cristatus » pp128–29
- **Nile monitor**
Varanus niloticus » p227
- **Panther chameleon**
Furcifer pardalis » p242
- **Przewalski's wonder gecko**
Teratoscincus przewalskii » p283
- **Thorny devil**
Moloch horridus » p332

Amphisbaenians

Order Amphisbaenia

Speckled worm lizard

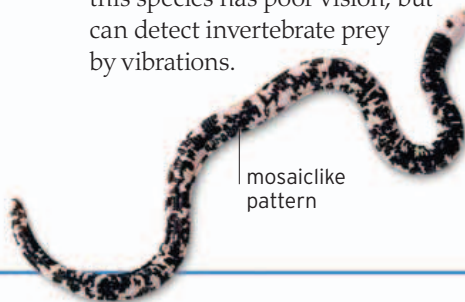
Amphisbaena fuliginosa

- ↔ 12–18 in (30–45 cm)
- 📍 N. South America, Trinidad
- ⊗ Not known

Worm lizards are burrowing reptiles, with a superficial resemblance to earthworms or snakes—but they are most

closely related to the family that includes sand and viviparous lizards. Like other worm lizards, this species has poor vision, but can detect invertebrate prey by vibrations.

mosaiclike pattern



Crocodiles and alligators

Order Crocodylia

Black caiman

Melanosuchus niger

- ↔ 13–20 ft (4–6 m)
- 📍 N. South America
- ⊗ Locally common

Caimans are members of the alligator family characterized by a bony ridge running from eyes to snout. Most are smaller than true

alligators—even though this species is one of the largest predators in wetlands of Amazonia, and a fully grown black caiman is capable of bringing down a small deer. Its dark color provides camouflage, and a wide, heavy head means it has a strong bite. The female lays and guards 30–65 eggs and stays with the young after they hatch.

Saltwater crocodile

Crocodylus porosus

- ↔ 16–23 ft (5–7 m)
- 📍 SE. Asia to N. Australia
- ⊗ Common

The world's largest living reptile is a formidable predator, capable of preying on large mammals. Once the victim is grabbed, the crocodile rolls in the water to drown the prey. Unlike most other crocodilians, it can swim considerable distances out to sea. This salt tolerance means the species can disperse between islands—and this has helped to make it widespread throughout Southeast Asia and Australasia.

Dwarf crocodile

Osteolaemus tetraspis

- ↔ 6 ft (1.8 m)
- 📍 W. and C. Africa
- ⊗ Vulnerable

This shy, nocturnal reptile is one of the smallest of crocodilians and quickly dives under water when disturbed. It inhabits rainforest wetlands in tropical Africa, where

it hides during the day in burrows or beneath tree roots. At night, it feeds near the water's edge. The dwarf crocodile hunts for fish during the wettest months, but turns to bankside crustaceans and amphibians during the dry season.

Other species

- **American alligator**
Alligator mississippiensis » p72
- **Gharial**
Gavialis gangeticus » p265
- **Nile crocodile**
Crocodylus niloticus » p191
- **Yacare caiman**
Caiman yacare » pp106–07

yellowish underside with black patches

bony plates cover body

blunt snout

